Paper 13 — When Non-Convexity Has No Bad Minima

Rong Ge, Chi Jin and Yi Zheng (ICML 2017)

No Spurious Local Minima in Nonconvex Low Rank Problems: A Unified Geometric Analysis

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The paper in one minute

Question: Can a non-convex problem have *no suboptimal local minima*, so every genuine local optimum solves the original task?
Model/Method: Recover a low-rank matrix from measurements, missing entries, or sparse corruptions. Factor it as $M = UV^\top$ and analyze gradients and Hessian curvature.
Finding: For the paper's regularized matrix sensing, completion, and robust-PCA formulations, under explicit assumptions, all local minima are global; nonoptimal stationary points have escaping curvature (or a smooth-upper-bound analogue).
Why we care: Non-convexity alone does not force bad minima. Combine a *benign landscape* with a saddle-escaping optimizer and global recovery can become possible.

1. First understand the task: recover a simple matrix

Consider a large matrix M^* that is **low rank**: its rows or columns contain redundant information. For example, in a recommendation matrix, user preferences may depend on only a few underlying factors. Three recovery problems ask us to infer M^* from different observations:

Matrix sensing	Observe linear measurements $b_i = \langle A_i, M^* \rangle$.
Matrix completion	Observe a randomly sampled subset of the entries of M^*.
Robust PCA	Observe $M_{\text{obs}} = M^* + S^*$ with sparse corruptions S^*.

The rank constraint makes recovery non-convex. A standard trick replaces the matrix with two smaller factors:

$$M = UV^\top, \qquad U \in \mathbb{R}^{d_1 \times r}, \quad V \in \mathbb{R}^{d_2 \times r}.$$

Even if the data-fit function $f(M)$ is convex *in* M, the composition $f(UV^\top)$ is generally **non-convex in** U, V. The paper asks whether that non-convexity creates harmful minima.

Keep the scope straight: This is a theorem about *structured low-rank recovery objectives*, not a theorem stating that arbitrary deep neural networks have no bad local minima. The lesson transfers conceptually, not automatically.

2. Worked example: a saddle with zero gradient

Take a tiny symmetric rank-one target, with a rank-one model $M = uu^\top$:

$$M^* = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad u = \begin{bmatrix} a \\ b \end{bmatrix}, \qquad F(a,b) = \frac{1}{2}\|uu^\top - M^*\|_F^2.$$

Step 1 — Expand the loss. Because $uu^\top = \left[\begin{smallmatrix} a^2 & ab \\ ab & b^2 \end{smallmatrix}\right]$, sum the squared entrywise errors:

$$F(a,b) = \frac{1}{2}\left[(a^2-1)^2 + 2a^2b^2 + b^4\right] = \frac{1}{2}\left[(a^2+b^2)^2 - 2a^2 + 1\right].$$

Step 2 — Calculate gradient and stationary points.

$$\frac{\partial F}{\partial a} = 2a(a^2+b^2-1), \qquad \frac{\partial F}{\partial b} = 2b(a^2+b^2).$$

Both derivatives are zero at $(a,b) = (0,0)$, and also at $(\pm 1, 0)$. **Step 3 — Is $(0,0)$ a minimum?** The Hessian there is

$$\nabla^2 F(0,0) = \begin{bmatrix} -2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad \lambda_{\min} = -2 < 0.$$

It has a *negative-curvature direction*. Along $b = 0$:

$$F(a,0) = \tfrac{1}{2}(a^2-1)^2; \quad F(0,0) = 0.5, \quad F(0.5,0) = 0.28125, \quad F(1,0) = 0.$$

Step 4 — Identify the true minima. At $u = (\pm 1, 0)^\top$, we recover M^* exactly, so $F = 0$. These are global minima; $(0,0)$ is a *strict saddle*, not a bad local minimum.

What this teaches: The loss is non-convex in the factor u, and it has a zero-gradient point with positive loss. Yet that point has an escaping curvature direction. *Zero gradient does not equal local minimum.* This calculation is a pedagogical full-observation example, not a proof of the paper's general theorems.

3. The theorem in plain English

Under their hypotheses, any putative local minimum of the relevant factorized objectives must reconstruct M^*. Otherwise the authors can exhibit a direction that lowers the objective; in particular, a nonoptimal stationary point has a negative-curvature direction (or a suitable generalization). Thus **no spurious local minima** and **strict-saddle geometry** complement each other.

4. Why the geometry is favorable: the proof's central trick

The unifying idea is that the data-fit loss is quadratic in the matrix M and has a Hessian operator $\mathcal{H}$ that approximately preserves squared Frobenius lengths *on relevant low-rank directions*. For a symmetric factorization $M = UU^\top$, first align the current factor with the true factor:

$$\Delta = U - U^*R, \qquad R \text{ orthogonal, chosen to minimize } \|U - U^*R\|_F.$$

Why align? U and UR represent the *same* matrix for orthogonal R; comparing raw factors without alignment can mistake equivalent solutions for different ones. **Lemma 7 (main identity):** For $M = UU^\top$ and the regularized objective, the Hessian quadratic form in the aligned direction Δ decomposes as

$$\begin{aligned}\langle \Delta, \nabla^2 F(U)\Delta\rangle = \langle \Delta\Delta^\top, \mathcal{H}(\Delta\Delta^\top)\rangle - 3\langle M - M^*, \mathcal{H}(M - M^*)\rangle \\ + 4\langle \nabla F_{\text{data}}(U), \Delta\rangle + \text{regularizer correction}.\end{aligned}$$

Read the signs, not every symbol: the first term is positive, but the *minus three times reconstruction error* term is negative. Under the norm-preservation and regularizer conditions, at a nonoptimal stationary point the negative part wins, proving negative curvature.

Idealized case $\mathcal{H} = I$, no regularizer: At a stationary point, Lemma 7 and Lemma 6 yield

$$\langle \Delta, \nabla^2 F(U)\Delta\rangle = \|\Delta\Delta^\top\|_F^2 - 3\|M - M^*\|_F^2 \le -\|M - M^*\|_F^2.$$

If $M \neq M^*$, the right side is negative: the point cannot be a local minimum. This is the essence of the unified proof.

5. RIP and the regularizer: what are they doing?

Restricted Isometry Property (RIP). For measurement matrices A_i, the paper assumes a nearly length-preserving observation map on low-rank matrices:

$$(1 - \delta)\|X\|_F^2 \le \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m}\langle A_i, X\rangle^2 \le (1 + \delta)\|X\|_F^2 \quad (\text{rank } X \le r).$$

Intuition: Two sufficiently different low-rank matrices should not look identical after measurement. Otherwise the observations would hide a direction of the solution space.

For asymmetric factors, the balancing penalty

$$Q_{\text{bal}}(U, V) = \tfrac{1}{8}\|U^\top U - V^\top V\|_F^2$$

discourages arbitrarily mismatched factor scales (e.g., replacing U by cU and V by V/c). In matrix completion, *additional* regularizers keep factors in incoherent regions where observation geometry remains well behaved.

6. What is actually proved, for which problems?

Problem / result	Key assumptions	Conclusion in the paper
Matrix sensing, Theorem 3	$(2r, 1/20)$-RIP for the measurement map; balanced asymmetric factors	Every local minimum has $UV^\top = M^*$; quantitative strict-saddle property.
Matrix completion, Theorem 4	μ-incoherent target, sufficiently many uniformly sampled entries, regularizers and conditioning	With high probability, no spurious local minima and quantitative strict-saddle geometry.
Robust PCA, Theorem 5	Incoherent low-rank target, sufficiently sparse corruptions and bounded corruption assumptions	All local minima recover the low-rank component; *pseudo*-strict-saddle property.

Why "pseudo" for robust PCA? The loss minimizes over a sparse correction S and need not be twice differentiable in (U, V). The authors use a smooth upper-bounding function touching the loss locally and test its negative Hessian curvature. Don't incorrectly describe Theorem 5 as an ordinary smooth strict-saddle theorem.

7. What the paper does not claim

- **Not universal:** remove the measurement/incoherence/sparsity assumptions and bad minima may appear; this is not a result about arbitrary neural-network losses.
- **Not "GD from any point always works":** at an exact saddle such as $U = 0$, unmodified GD can remain stationary. Polynomial-time global recovery relies on combining the landscape with suitable saddle-escaping algorithms and their conditions.
- **Not generalization:** recovery of the specified matrix is different from generalization guarantees for neural networks.
- **Not a new optimizer:** the contribution is chiefly a *unified landscape proof*, not a new SGD or perturbed-GD update.

8. Survey connections: the question this paper resolves

Paper	How to connect them without overstating either result
Safran–Shamir (2018)	Some simple ReLU objectives *do* have bad local minima; the low-rank models here show an important favorable counterexample class.
Lee (2016)	Avoidance of strict saddles is useful if all remaining local minima are globally optimal. This paper supplies that geometry for specific models.
Jin (2017)	Finite-time saddle escape + benign strict-saddle landscape can imply efficient global recovery under additional regularity conditions.
Du / Allen-Zhu (2019)	Strong global training-loss results also require structured assumptions, but for wide neural-network architectures rather than matrix recovery.

Survey takeaway: The hard question is not "Is the objective non-convex?" but "What kinds of stationary points does its structure permit?" Ge et al. identify models with global local minima and escaping saddles; Safran–Shamir identify neural models with genuine bad minima.

9. Quick reference

Concept	Meaning in one line
Factorization	$M = UV^\top$ turns rank-restricted recovery into unconstrained, non-convex optimization.
No spurious minima	Every local minimum reconstructs M^* under the stated assumptions.
Strict-saddle	Away from local minima: sizeable gradient or negative Hessian curvature.
RIP	Measurements approximately preserve the Frobenius norm of low-rank changes.
Incoherence	Matrix information is spread across coordinates, making entry sampling informative.
Main proof tool	Lemma 7: aligned-factor displacement creates a negative-curvature certificate.

10. Papers Master note (purple column)

Ge et al. (2017) prove no spurious local minima and (pseudo-)strict-saddle geometry in low-rank sensing, completion and robust PCA under structural assumptions. Lemma 7 gives a curvature certificate; this does not directly cover neural networks.